

IMPULSIVE BEHAVIOR JOURNAL

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Increase awareness of impulsive behaviors.
2. Identify thoughts, feelings, or circumstances that may trigger impulsive behavior.
3. Clarify the consequences of impulsive behavior.
4. Acknowledge that impulsive behavior leads to negative consequences for self and others.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- Attention-Deficit Disorder (ADD)—Adult
- Borderline Personality
- Chemical Dependence
- Chemical Dependence—Relapse
- Financial Stress
- Legal Conflicts
- Mania or Hypomania
- Type A Behavior

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

You may need to review the details of this assignment to help the client better understand what the homework calls for. The client may tend toward minimization and/or may be out of touch with his/her feelings. Examine the completed journal material for unrealistic, distorted thoughts that trigger feelings and actions of an impulsive nature. Use cognitive change techniques to counteract these distorted thoughts and replace them with more realistic cognitions. Reinforce all verbalizations of acceptance of responsibility for negative consequences related to impulsive actions.

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It is sometimes difficult to become aware of our own patterns of behavior, the triggers for those behaviors, and the results of those behaviors. We tend to be blind to our own behavior patterns and their results. Often other people have to confront us with our behavior and the painful consequences caused by our actions. We tend to minimize the negative consequences and to highlight the positive results that we see. This exercise is designed to increase your awareness of your own behavior patterns related to impulsive actions and their results. You will need to tune in to your own thoughts and feelings as well as be vigilant about the consequences of your actions.

1. Please enter information regarding seven incidents in which you acted impulsively. You may want to select one incident per day over the next week. For each incident enter the Day/Date/Time that the incident occurred. Describe where you were when the incident occurred (Place). Describe what was going on around you prior to your impulsive action (Situation). Next, describe what you were thinking and what your emotions were (Thoughts and Feelings). Then describe the behavior that you engaged in that was done without thoroughly thinking it through (Impulsive Act). Finally, describe what you saw as the consequences of your behavior (Result). Repeat the entry of this data for the seven impulsive behavior incidents.

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Entry 1 Day/Date and Time: 	Place	
	Situation	
	Thoughts	
	Feelings	
	Impulsive Act	
	Result	

Entry 2 Day/Date and Time: 	Place	
	Situation	
	Thoughts	
	Feelings	
	Impulsive Act	
	Result	

Entry 3 Day/Date and Time: 	Place	
	Situation	
	Thoughts	
	Feelings	
	Impulsive Act	
	Result	

Entry 4 Day/Date and Time: 	Place	
	Situation	
	Thoughts	
	Feelings	
	Impulsive Act	
	Result	

Entry 5 Day/Date and Time: 	Place	
	Situation	
	Thoughts	
	Feelings	
	Impulsive Act	
	Result	

Entry 6 Day/Date and Time: 	Place	
	Situation	
	Thoughts	
	Feelings	
	Impulsive Act	
	Result	

Entry 7 Day/Date and Time: 	Place	
	Situation	
	Thoughts	
	Feelings	
	Impulsive Act	
	Result	

2. List the results of your impulsive actions (e.g., made me feel better, reduced my anger, got back at somebody, felt more relaxed afterwards).

3. List all of the negative consequences that have occurred because of your impulsive behavior (e.g., loss of money, embarrassment to self or others, injury to self or others, broken promises, lost friendships).

4. As you review your impulsive behavior, what triggers for these actions can you identify (e.g., thoughts or feelings, a particular situation, a person or place)?

5. What connection do you see between your impulsive behavior and the painful consequences for yourself or others?
